and the question of whether or not to trust the US never arose, and should never arise, pressed Vajpayee. India could only have secured its national interests in such circumstances, Jaswant Singh argued, by 'influencing [the situation] not through staying away, but influencing through engagement, and having engaged, influencing through persuasion'.[103] If such influence does not work, and India sees that any country is acting in a fashion that is not conducive to India's national interest, then New Delhi will have nothing to do with that country. But 'prejudice' cannot be a good foundation of India's foreign policy. As for the killing of innocents, Vajpayee conceded to that point and agreed to raise it with Washington.

In contrast to the heated debate on US actions post 9/11, and India's response to the same, all Indian policymakers were in agreement that Afghanistan should remain united and develop as a broad-based multiethnic democratic polity, which does not allow its soil to be used as a training ground for terrorists, and for infiltration into India.[104] Some opposition MPs also recommended that instead of the administrative burden being borne by any single country administration, the UN should manage Afghanistan in its transition period, just like Cambodia was after the fall of the Khmer Rouge. The UF, which had entered Kabul with US armed support, were being widely welcomed in India. Barring SP's Janeshwar Mishra, who worried that whoever comes to power in Kabul will be an American 'stooge' (Hamid Karzai was indeed called such until he fell out of favour with his Western benefactors years later), most political parties were confident that the UF leaders such as Burhanuddin Rabbani, Abdullah Abdullah, Faheem Khan, Yunus Qanooni, Ismail Khan, Dostum, or even the former king Zahir Shah, would be ideal to form the government.[105]

Underlining the dominance of anti-Pakistan partisanship in the Parliament, both the government and the opposition emphasised that no Taliban member should be given political space in the post 2001 Afghanistan.[106] Even Hekmatyar, who was dependent on Pakistan and had political currency in some pockets of Afghanistan, should be kept at arm's length. Despite the US military intervention, India was convinced that the Taliban had not been destroyed. It had only been displaced to the mountains of Afghanistan, or the tribal regions of Pakistan, from where it could easily launch an insurgency against the US forces,